



Ozone killers at large

Ozone depleting chemicals have been discovered unexpectedly in high levels in the atmosphere by NASA <http://dgit.in/BannedOzChem>



Impressive sci-fi short film

This is a short film which shows how an alien race can transform a barren planet into a paradise <http://dgit.in/SciFiShort>

A Primer to Anonymous Social Sharing

Secret

Platforms: Android and iOS

Website: <https://www.secret.ly/>

"I sometimes try getting bit by spiders just in case I get superpowers. I'm 30."

Secret requires you to sign up with your email ID, Facebook login or local cell number. Using your contacts, it creates circles of friends whose posts and activity you can follow. You can't know specifically who in your circle is posting but can see it in your feed. The greater the number of people in your circle, the more location details are shared. Even without the minimum three friends on Secret, you're free to view posts liked by your friends or from the global pool. Just remember to "Unlink my posts" from settings to truly gain anonymity.

Whisper

Platforms: Android and iOS

Website: <http://whisper.sh/stories/#>

"My boyfriend keeps trying to feed me because he thinks I'll leave him if I'm good looking. He's right."

Whisper is the more punk version of Secret. It has an instant signing up process, which needs no email ID or phone contacts to share. You can read Whispers

from as close as within 1 mile or go global with a switch of the tabs. You can comment on posts or chat with posters, who are just as anonymous as you. If you want to invite friends there's an option to do so via phone contacts, email, Facebook and Twitter in the "Me" settings. Here, you can also choose a new pseudonym each time you post and view the history of your hearts (likes) and Whispers. And be sure to keep the NSFW toggle off if you want a clean timeline.

Leak

Website: <http://justleak.it/>

"To: Boss From: Co-worker Message: I spit in your coffee everyday because you treat me like shit."

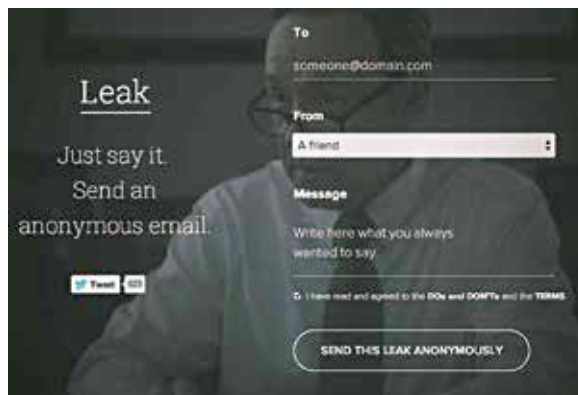
There isn't much to explain about Leak. It's an ingenious web service that allows users to send email to anyone while protecting the sender's identity. Just pop in the recipient's email ID, your relation to them (optional) and your message. Hit "send" and you're done. They can't reply or trace the origin of the email. Currently the site is undergoing downtime over technical (ahem...legal) issues, but assures its users that it will be back in full force very soon.

But as you begin to navigate these waters, you'll discover that such places are quirky little worlds in themselves. In the case of one-sided anonymous services like Leak and chatting apps like Kik and Snapchat, there's a more direct emotional payoff. You're able to get things off your chest without risking being identified. However, while you can shed the self-consciousness sometimes necessary on other social media networks and say what you want, you can't really get the one thing you're probably looking for from a social sharing space – validation.

This fact is corroborated by research done by the Psychology of Popular Media Culture Journal and the American Psychologists Association that has enough evidence to prove the high need for validation in people who actively share on social networks. This need is hard-wired into our social psyche, where we feel satisfaction

and happiness when someone reacts to our thoughts. Whether it's an image on Instagram or a clever phrase on Twitter, users want a response, preferably a positive one. In its absence, they can become depressed and despondent.

What an irony that the freedom of anonymous social media comes at the cost of emotional validation! The need to be listened to is just as important (if not more so) than the need to speak freely.



The Leak website lets individuals quickly and securely let others know what's on their mind through an anonymous system generated email

And since there's no guarantee that what you say will interest complete strangers and promote likability, many users won't abandon traditional social media for such sites. And even in the cases that it does – with thousands of likes, hearts, comments and shares on your content – users will never be able to claim the credit.

Sex, lies and libel: The culture of making s#@ up

Like everything else in technology, the virtue of a tool is in its use to the person wielding it. Just as a hammer can build or destroy, the way in which people use services like Whisper, Leak and Confess will eventually define how their legacies emerge. If we were to look at how anonymity works in other instances, we might get a fair guess of what will happen.

Just scrolling through the comments list on a YouTube video or reading tweets targetted at Justin Bieber is enough to demonstrate that nutjobs still exist online. From trolling threads and engaging in flame wars to threatening violence against strangers on behalf of celebrities, the protection of anonymity allows for greater expression of anger, hate and malice.

On another part of the spectrum is the propensity of people to engage in gossip – the needless passing around of other people's private information for public amusement. It's not rare to see Page 3 headlines pulled from these services, where anonymous users claim to have inside scoop on celebrities' personal lives. Under the garb of "unconfirmed reports" and "inside sources", rumours find easier footing and the need to believe the illusive compels widespread sharing. Taken too far by some, this new medium could become a hunting ground for cyber bullies who will be free to target anyone, with no consequences for spreading false information regarding real people. There are dangers we've already seen with suicide attempts and cases of depression being attributed to cyber bullying among kids on the internet. The anonymity in sharing will only embolden such negative acts since accountability will no longer be traceable.

The political and corporate risk that these services pose has already been seen